

Puerto Rico: Disaster, Neglect, And The Fight For Statehood [C1]

Gli uragani del 2017 non hanno solo devastato Porto Rico, ma hanno anche messo in evidenza la fragilità delle sue infrastrutture e riaperto i dibattiti su identità, disuguaglianza e status politico.



In 2017 hurricanes Irma and Maria devastated Puerto Rico, [compounding](#) its existing economic fragility. The storms [knocked out](#) the entire [power grid](#), [disrupted](#) water service for weeks in many areas, and virtually shut down cellular communications. The official [death toll](#) was initially reported as sixty-four but was later revised to an estimated 2,982 based on excess mortality studies. Around 130,000 Puerto Ricans left the island for the US [mainland](#) in the months following the storms. Overall damage was estimated at \$90 billion, making these hurricanes the third costliest in US history. **Dr. Lorrin Thomas:** Puerto Rico has experienced a number of major hurricanes. There was a really major hurricane in the early 1930s that was devastating, especially because it happened during the Great Depression and, you know, a [handful](#) of others that really caused tremendous destruction. So Hurricane Irma, which was like ten days before Hurricane Maria in 2017 — together they were kind of this [one-two punch](#)—, they were terrible, and they would have been terrible [no matter what](#), but the real disastrous impact was a result of broken infrastructure and a government that could not support a disaster effort locally to help rescue people who were suffering [in the aftermath of](#) the hurricane. People, especially in rural areas, were left without power, without fresh water, without any ability to get medications. And it couldn't do that because the economy had been devastated over the previous decade.

INSUFFICIENT AID

In the aftermath of the 2017 hurricanes, the Trump administration faced widespread criticism for its slow and inadequate response to Puerto Rico's crisis. Federal [aid](#) was [delayed](#), logistical support [lagged](#), and resources were often insufficient to meet urgent needs. Public statements by President Trump, including [disparaging remarks](#) about the island and its residents, [fuelled outrage](#) and highlighted the unequal treatment of Puerto Rico compared with US states affected by similar disasters. Entertainment

Bad Bunny: Puerto Rican Global Superstar È stato l'artista più ascoltato nel 2025. La sua musica, influenzata dallo stile portoricano, è un simbolo di rivendicazione delle proprie origini. Sarah Davison, Melita Cameron-Wood **Dr. Lorrin Thomas:** Most people probably remember the kind of [glib scorn](#) with which President Trump treated Puerto Rico. Trump was so [dismissive](#), but functionally, it was even worse. For a while, there was a restriction on [shipping](#). This had to do with, like, an old piece of legislation, like 1920, that meant that more people died because medicines didn't reach the island, generators didn't reach the island. [A] really, truly shocking [outcome](#) for a colony of the United States that had already suffered from this [lack](#) of sovereignty, [lack](#) of self-determination to manage its own affairs.

STATEHOOD

Puerto Rico's experience with Hurricane Maria intensified long-standing frustrations over the island's political status. Many residents, already critical of colonialism and the limitations of [Commonwealth status](#), saw the slow federal response as evidence of systemic neglect. **Dr. Lorrin Thomas:** The impact of this terrible experience with Hurricane Maria, it only amplified the arguments or it [gave even more credence to](#) the arguments that people on the [statehood](#) end of the spectrum have been making, which is, "If we were a state, we wouldn't be in this position. We would have all the [aid](#) we needed, you know, we would have representation, we would have had access to all kinds of other resources that the island is cut off from."

IN THE SHADOW OF THE US

Puerto Rico's identity is shaped by colonialism. Nearly two-thirds of Puerto Ricans live outside the island, forming a large and influential diaspora, especially in states like Florida, New York, Pennsylvania, and New Jersey. While the island has an estimated population of 3.23 million people, there are almost six million people of Puerto Rican origin living in the fifty US states and Washington D.C. This includes both those born in Puerto Rico and those with Puerto Rican ancestry. Migration [surged](#) after Hurricane Maria: 77,000 Puerto Ricans, or 2.4 per cent of its inhabitants, migrated to the US. **Dr. Lorrin Thomas:** So many Puerto Ricans migrated in the couple of years after the hurricanes, after 2017, largely because there was so little left. I mean, there were so few options. Their worldview, their politics, their everyday experience, their political identity is fundamentally shaped, and many people would say distorted, by having had to contend with domination by a global superpower. Puerto Ricans have the potential to be part of a bigger economy, like work for US firms on the island or leave the island and get better jobs as labour migrants in the United States. But it's all fundamentally shaped by living in a place that was not self-determining, that was not just kind of its own. It always had this shadow of US control.

LANGUAGE AND IDENTITY

When the US [took over](#) Puerto Rico in 1898, a military government was set up to try and 'Americanize' the island. The goal was to teach young Puerto Rican students American customs and values and build loyalty to US interests. Language played a major role in this effort. In the early 1900s, schools began [switching](#) from Spanish to English. By 1902, English had become the main language of instruction, and many US teachers were [hired](#). Puerto Rican teachers started to resist the forced use of English and formed the Puerto Rican Teachers Association. Over time, continued resistance led officials to make Spanish the primary

language in schools. This [strengthened](#) after Puerto Ricans were [allowed](#) to elect their own governor in 1948 and Luis Muñoz Marín — a leader who had long supported Puerto Rican sovereignty — was elected. Since 1949, public schools have mainly used Spanish, while many private schools offer bilingual or English-only programs, especially in urban areas like San Juan and Ponce. English is taught as a [mandatory subject](#) from early elementary school through high school and college. Today, English and Spanish are both official languages. Because of the island's close relationship with the US, English appears widely in media and daily life, and many Puerto Ricans mix English words into their Spanish. [Despite](#) English being taught in schools, [surveys](#) show that most Puerto Ricans are not fluent in English, and Spanish remains the language of identity and culture for the majority. If you want to know more about this topic, read the article [Puerto Rico And Its Relationship With The United States](#).

Glossary

- **knocked out** = mettere fuori servizio
- **scorn** = disprezzo
- **outcome** = esito
- **Commonwealth status** = condizione di Stato libero associato
- **switching** = cambiare
- **allowed** = permettere
- **disrupted** = interrompere
- **one-two punch** = doppio colpo (lett. combinazione uno-due del pugilato)
- **lagged** = tardare
- **lack** = mancanza
- **gave even more credence to** = dare credito a
- **surged** = impennarsi
- **Despite** = nonostante
- **mainland** = continente
- **aid** = aiuto
- **delayed** = ritardare
- **disparaging** = denigratori
- **fuelled** = alimentare
- **outrage** = indignazione
- **strengthened** = rafforzare
- **power grid** = rete elettrica
- **death toll** = bilancio delle vittime
- **no matter what** = in ogni caso
- **glib** = frivolo
- **dismissive** = offensivo
- **statehood** = status di stato
- **took over** = assumere il controllo
- **compounding** = aggravare
- **shipping** = trasporto
- **mandatory subject** = materia obbligatoria
- **surveys** = sondaggi
- **handful** = manciata
- **in the aftermath of** = come conseguenza di
- **remarks** = commenti
- **hired** = assumere